

GIRL, INTERRUPTED

This Booker-listed first novel is a page-turner that captures the poignancy of growing up as a prodigy



GIFTED
by NIKITA LALWANI
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■ By Brinda Bose

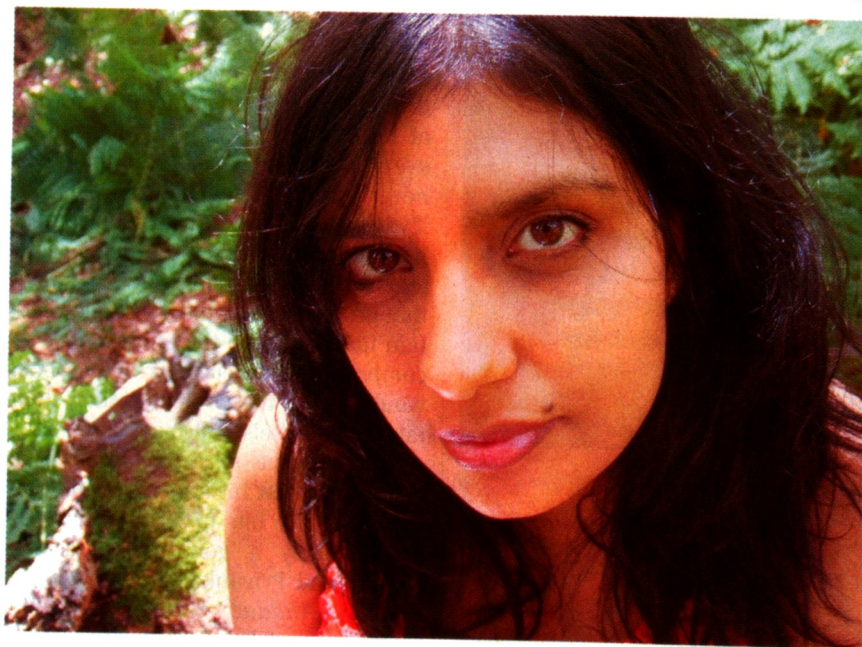
What can I say about a 34-year-old's first novel that has just been long-listed for the Man Booker Prize of 2007? That I came to it with obvious expectations; that I hoped it would not turn out to be one more diasporic rant about the tribulations of growing up an NRI; that I imagined discovering in it a chance of making a self-fulfilling win-

tacted, awkward youngster growing up in a middle-class immigrant Indian family in Cardiff, Wales, whose parents' inchoate ambition for glory in an alien land is ignited when they discover that she is a mathematics prodigy. A university lecturer in mathematics, Rumi's father Mahesh fixes his dream on a still point: that his 'gifted' daughter should find fame for them all by taking her school examinations ahead of time and entering Oxford University as an underage undergraduate student. Her mother Shreene is co-opted into the single-minded pursuit of this aspiration; only her baby brother Nibu provides Rumi with some semblance of

Does she make her A-level grades? Does she make it to Oxford? Does she dazzle the dons there? And does the boy she fancies in high school fancy another, as her cruel classmates tell her? Does she look weird in her mother's lipstick and foundation? Do her contact lenses dry up during a long flight to India as she fears, so that she must don her abhorred spectacles when she lands? Will the 20-year-old Fareed of Balliol College, who thinks she is "kind of beautiful crazy" when he discovers her at the Oxford Asian Society's "jazz and samosas" evening, still be mesmerised by her when he learns that she is only 15-pretending-to-be-adult? And why is her father so maniacally incensed when he discovers her unsent love letters to this young man, whose name brands him with a dreaded identity?

Lalwani's *Gifted* has sombre clouds brooding over its multiple realities, reflections of a conglomerate of essentially "Indian" obsessions in the diasporic space, intellectual, historical, emotional, communal. A manic desire to prove oneself culturally and academically superior in the land of the whites. A dubious hankering for children to remain "true" to Indian heritage, interpreted through a haze of nostalgia by displaced, dismembered parents. A lunatic reiteration of historical memory, perpetuating communal hatred, losing all perspective and reason. *Gifted* should make all Indian parents look hard in the mirror: it is possible to desire, dominate and dictate too much, and thereby to disaffect what is most precious and loved: one's child.

Lalwani's singular achievement is that she touches our souls without pedantic moralising or exhortative homiletics. Rumi's parents are believable monsters, they lurk in all of us. The spunky, captivating Rumika—gifted without doubt but adorably ordinary at the same time—is also someone we have sighted and sighed over, in ourselves or in our children. And Lalwani is certainly a gifted writer, Booker or not.



GIFTED STORYTELLER: Lalwani touches our souls without moralising childhood innocence and exhilaration as she is catapulted into a horrifying vortex of discipline, reward, punishment and emotional blackmail in preparation for the extraordinary future mapped out for her.

What makes this novel exceptional is its ability to draw the reader unsuspectingly into this vortex, until one finds oneself feverishly riffling through its pages to find out what happens to Rumi as she stumbles through adolescence into adulthood before her time:

ning prophesy for the October prize. I wonder whether anyone has ever had three wishes in a row come true.

With no idea of how Lalwani's *Gifted* might measure up against many others on the Booker long-list that I have not read, it would be rather meaningless to attempt to calculate its chances for the prize. What I can say, however, is that here is an honest good read, poignant, eloquent and unpretentiously profound. Here is a page-turner without homicide, suicide, rape, lascivious sex or witchcraft: the lucid, fervent tale of Rumika Vasi, a bespec-